

Thanksgiving With My Indie Family

Sitting at the dinner table blows because I have to hear about all the ways everyone else made it big in life. Mom hit a four-figure salary on her pottery studio/cat cafe. Dad finished the first act of his high-concept, avant-horror screenplay. Grandma signed with an independent modeling agency, which means my cousin just got his first client at his independent modeling agency. When I'm inevitably asked what my life plans are, I pause, knowing that my answer will send shockwaves through the entire household. But now more than ever is time to tell my family the honest truth: "I want to become a mechanical engineer."

The room goes silent. Dad practically spits out his portobello steak. Mom chuckles for a moment before realizing that I'm being serious. "Honey, we've discussed this," she chides, her words caked with embarrassment. "I can't have a child who's relegated himself to the capitalist industrial machine."

All my life, my mother and father imposed strict expectations on me: get good grades in school, enroll in a good college, drop out immediately and become a starving artist. But I have dreams of my own. Dreams like building quality-grade heating and cooling systems for middle to upper-middle class Americans, or possibly hinges.

So, I rebelled. In high school, I'd stay up late learning Fluid Dynamics on the family computer, switching the tab to feminist zines if mom ever walked through the living room. At eighteen, I mustered up the courage to sneak out of the house entirely, at 8:45AM, every Monday through Friday, to work my internship at IBM.

And now it's time to rip off the bandaid, once and for all. I flash everyone my one-way bus ticket to the cultural hub of aspiring mechanical engineers: Rochester, New York. The room recoils. Rochester has fewer than fifteen jazz bars in the entire city. "But at least you don't have a plan for where you're staying, right? Facing the world with just the clothes on your back and the things that you can carry?" I shake my head, having just signed a year-long lease on a modest one-bedroom apartment. Grandma falls out of her mid-century modern stepstool.

After that, dinner's tense, my parents seething with a silent rage that could only be expelled through an auto-fiction published to their joint substack. Grandma mutters expletives I haven't heard since I went to prom with a member of the opposite gender. I think I've lost them for good until suddenly, my younger brother stands up to speak. He's the prodigy—having already read *The Bell Jar* and *Giovanni's Room* at the young age of nine—so when he talks, people listen: "I don't care if you get dental insurance or a 401(k). You're still my brother, no matter what." I burst into tears. Dad gives me a hug so tender I almost don't feel his rose-quartz nose ring digging into my shoulder.

I placate any remaining apprehension with my backup plan of long-form poetry. But on the inside, there's an excitement bubbling. A knowledge that someday soon, I'll have a cubicle to call my own. I'll have five-minute-long conversations with coworkers at the bi-monthly office pizza parties. Maybe I'll put a down payment on my first house and have missionary sex with one, even two women before finally settling down. The possibilities are as finite as finite can be.

Little Red Riding Hood If Her Cloak Was Actually Chartreuse

Little Chartreuse Riding Hood: Good morning, Mr. Wolf.

Big Bad Wolf: Good morning, Little (*mumble*) Riding Hood!

Little Chartreuse Riding Hood: What was that?

Big Bad Wolf: I said good morning, Little (*mumble*) Riding Hood!

Little Chartreuse Riding Hood: Oh, okay.

Big Bad Wolf: Might you be heading to your grandmother's with that basket?

Little Chartreuse Riding Hood: Do you not know how to pronounce the word chartreuse?

Big Bad Wolf: Where is your grandmother located?

Little Chartreuse Riding Hood: You don't know, do you.

Big Bad Wolf: Of course I do.

Little Chartreuse Riding Hood: Then say it.

Big Bad Wolf: ...

Big Bad Wolf: ...

Big Bad Wolf: Chabtoose.

Charlotte's Web

Papa raises his axe, ready to send runt-pig Wilbur back to the soil from which he came. All of a sudden, he sees a spider in the corner of the pen, its web spelling out the words: "SPARE HIM." He swipes it away, killing Charlotte instantly. But behind her is another spider, Randy. His web spells out: "PENIS." Papa keels over with laughter, unable to finish the job. Wilbur is saved.

Randy is an immediate hit among all farm community members ages 16 and below and male, as well as ages 17 and above and male, as well as female. Crowds gather, day after day, attempting to predict Randy's new word. COOCHIE? TAIN'T? He surpasses their expectations every time: PENIS. Oh Randy!

Every night, Randy re-spins his web while Wilbur pleads for his life: "My good Randy, please never stop the PENIS web. If you do...I'm toast!" Randy sits, unmoving. Wilbur continues: "I knew I could count on you, Randy!" Randy blinks. "We have fun, don't we Randy?" A fly gets stuck between the 'E' and the 'N'. Randy bites its head off and eats it.

But one day, Wilbur wakes up to an unfinished web and Randy fast asleep. "Randy, the PENIS!" Wilbur looks back to townspeople approaching, holding pitchforks and regular forks. Both are scary for Wilbur. "RAANNNDY!" Randy opens one of eight eyes. Townspeople reach the web, disappointed: "'PEN?' That's a dumb word. 'PENI?' Huh? Wow, Randy's really gone downhi—Oh my God. No way. No freaking way. 'PENIS.' Randy, you dog!" The crowd erupts. Wilbur breathes an oink of relief. Randy has done it again.

Then one day Randy's web says "COEXIST" and everyone leaves. Papa stops laughing. Wilbur is dead by morning.

Electric Chair

I'm sitting in the electric chair. As the executioner pulls the switch, my entire life flashes before my eyes:

Age Zero: I don't remember this.

Age One: I don't remember this.

Age Two: I don't remember this.

Age Three: *I wake up in the morning drenched in my own pee. That's okay. I've been doing it less and less these days. I open my fist. There's a Cheerio in it. Score. I eat the Cheerio. It tastes like pee. Now it's time to yell for Mother. "Mother!" I yell. She and Father come running. "Happy Birthday!" They say in unison. "Do you know how old that makes you?" No. I'm three. Father tries to lift me out of my race-car bed. He doesn't know about the pee yet. I slip out of his hands.*

Age Four: I kill my entire family.

3000 volts of electricity shoot through my body. I am the youngest person ever to be executed by the state.

SWIM MEET

COMIX BY DRR & BDL

